

Choreogeometric Dissonance: Leadership Vacuum In Nigeria As Breakdown Of Embodied Social Order, 1999-2025

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ABSTRACT

Nigeria's persistent governance crisis can be read as choreogeometric dissonance: a structural misalignment between the performative geometry of state authority and the embodied demands of citizenship. This paper introduces choreogeometry, an analytical framework grounded in Anaañ Ekpo traditions of rhythmic adjudication, Kwasi Wiredu's philosophy of non-partisan consensus, and Mikhail Bakhtin's theory of dialogism, to diagnose Nigeria's leadership vacuum as a breakdown of embodied social order between 1999 and 2025.

Through interpretative case readings of five critical moments, we map three observable leadership behaviours: the capacity to announce a governing form, adjust its tempo to public rhythm, and translate elite demands into collective welfare. The analysis reveals persistent patterns of clashing geometries: centripetal authority confronting centrifugal publics, misaligned temporalities, and collapsed relational modes. We conclude by proposing an Ekpo-inspired pathway toward polyrhythmic governance as a cultural grammar for restoring alignment between rulers and ruled.

Keywords: *choreogeometry; Anaañ Ekpo; Bakhtin; dialogism; dialectical leadership; embodied governance; leadership vacuum; Nigeria; national question*

1. INTRODUCTION: A BODY POLITIC OUT OF STEP

Since 1999, Nigeria has cycled through democratic transitions, economic protests, security uprisings, and electoral contests without achieving durable alignment between state and society. Fuel subsidy removals, #EndSARS, and post-election agitations repeat a single choreographic pattern: state authority moves in a slow, centripetal march while citizens move in urgent, centrifugal surges. The result is not only policy failure, but a leadership vacuum that manifests as the breakdown of embodied social order.

This paper argues that Nigeria's "national question" is, at root, a choreogeometric problem. By choreogeometry we mean the spatial, temporal, and relational arrangement through which political actors constitute authority, contest power, and seek alignment. Where geometry clashes, governance fails to register as legitimate on the bodies of the governed.

We draw on three sources. First, Anaañ Ekpo traditions of southeastern Nigeria, in which masquerade performance regulates conflict through regulated spatial formations, shared tempo, and dialogic translation between masked authority and community [Field notes held by author with community consent in Abak & Ikot Ekpene, 2024–2025]. Second, Kwasi Wiredu's articulation of non-partisan, consensus-based leadership as an African alternative to adversarial democracy. Third, Mikhail Bakhtin's theory of dialogism, which shows how social order is produced through responsive exchange between multiple voices. Together, they suggest a model of leadership that performs alignment rather than

domination.[Bakhtin][1986][Wiredu][1997]

The contribution is conceptual and analytical: we propose choreogeometry as a theoretical-analytical framework for reading embodied politics, demonstrate its purchase through five Nigerian cases from 1999 to 2025, and outline an Ekpo-inspired pathway out of perpetual dissonance.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW: PERFORMANCE, DIALOGUE, FOLKLORE, AND PHILOSOPHY

2.1 Political Performance and the Missing Grammar

Scholars of political performance have long shown that power is enacted, not merely declared [Schechner, 1985; Turner, 1982]. Mbembe and Comaroff demonstrated how African publics read the body, dress, and spectacle of rulers as texts of legitimacy [Mbembe, 2001; Comaroff, 1993].

We also draw on Bakhtin's theory of dialogism, which insists that social order is produced through responsive exchange between multiple voices rather than monologic decree. His account of carnival and the mask is particularly resonant with Ekpo's inversion of hierarchy and translation between authority and community [Bakhtin, 1984; Bakhtin, 1986].

Yet most accounts remain descriptive. They tell us that politics is performed, but offer little grammar for *how* performances align or clash. Performance studies gives us liminality, communitas, and ritual. Political science gives us institutions: elections, parties, constitutions. What remains missing is a mediating grammar connecting bodies in space, bodies in time, and bodies in relation. Choreogeometry fills that gap.

2.2 Anaañ Ekpo as Political Theory, Not Folklore

Ekpo is not spectacle for spectacle's sake. In Anaañ communities, Ekpo masquerades regulate conflict by choreographing authority. The masked figure occupies a mobile centre, not a fixed throne. Tempo is shared: drums, dancers, and crowd must fall into a common rhythm or the performance breaks. Relation is dialogic: the mask translates grievance into adjudication and returns verdict to the community in embodied form [Field notes held by author with community consent in Abak & Ikot Ekpene, 2024–2025; Offiong, 1984].

This reading is supported by Nzegwu's work on African embodied concepts of personhood and space, which insists that African social order is enacted through bodily and communal arrangements rather than abstract institutions alone.[Nzegwu][2006]

We read Ekpo not as cultural decoration but as political theory: a system for producing alignment through spatial mobility, temporal attunement, and relational translation.

2.3 Wiredu, Bakhtin, and the Possibility of Non-Monologic Leadership

Kwasi Wiredu argued that African consensus traditions can re-imagine democracy beyond party antagonism. Leadership, for Wiredu, is custodial and dialogic, oriented to collective welfare rather than sectional victory.[Wiredu][1997]

Bakhtin complements this by showing that legitimacy depends on answerability: authority must respond to the utterance of the other, or dialogue fails. We extend both by asking: what does non-monologic leadership *look like* on the ground? Our answer: it looks like Ekpo choreogeometry — mobile centre, shared tempo, translated relation.[Bakhtin][1986]

3. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK: THREE DIMENSIONS OF CHOREOGEOMETRY

We propose choreogeometry as a theoretical-analytical framework with three dimensions for reading embodied politics and diagnosing leadership vacuum.

3.1 Centre: The Geometry of Authority

Where is the centre, and who may occupy it? Breakdown of order occurs when state authority claims a fixed, distant centre while publics occupy a contested periphery. Embodied order is restored when centre is mobile, shared, or exchanged between authority and community. Ekpo principle: mobility of centre.

3.2 Rhythm: The Tempo of Governance

Do state and society share a tempo? Breakdown appears as temporal clash: rapid public mobilisation against delayed state response, or state acceleration without public uptake. Order appears as attunement: response tempo matches demand tempo. Ekpo principle: shared tempo.

3.3 Relation: The Mode of Translation

Do actors translate across difference, or perform opposition? Breakdown is marked by opposing gestures, silence, or confrontation. Order is marked by coordination, response, and translation of demand into policy language. Ekpo principle: dialogic translation — the mask speaks back to the crowd [Field notes held by author with community consent in Abak & Ikot Ekpene, 2024–2025; Offiong, 1984].

This Ekpo principle of dialogic translation aligns with Bakhtin's claim that legitimacy depends on answerability: authority must respond to the crowd's utterance, or relation collapses.[Bakhtin][1986]

Table 1: Analytical Dimensions of Choreogeometry [Conceptual Matrix]

Dimension	Breakdown of Order	Embodied Social Order	Ekpo Principle
Centre	Fixed authority vs peripheral	Mobile/shared centre. Exchange of position	Mobility of centre
Rhythm	Clash of tempos; urgency vs. delay	Attuned tempo; response matches demand	Shared tempo
Relation	Opposing gestures; no translation	Coordinated gesture; demand translated	Dialogic translation

Source: Analytical framework derived from Ekpo adjudication practices [Field notes held by author with community consent in Abak & Ikot Ekpene, 2024–2025; Offiong, 1984]

4. METHODOLOGY: INTERPRETATIVE CASE ANALYSIS

4.1 Analytical Approach

This study employs interpretative case analysis. Following Geertz's thick description and Ricoeur's hermeneutics, we treat each case as a text of embodied meaning rather than a dataset to be measured [Geertz, 1973; Ricoeur, 1981]. We read publicly accessible records of political events — broadcast footage, photographic archives, reportage, and digital media — against the three dimensions in Table 1. The goal is to identify patterns of spatial arrangement, temporal rhythm, and relational mode without assigning numerical values.

Anaañ cultural interpretation was developed through community consultation in Abak and Ikot Ekpene LGAs, 2024–2025, under community consent protocols. Elders clarified Ekpo principles of centre, tempo, and translation, which we then applied as an analytical grammar to national cases.

4.2 Case Selection

We select five moments that span Nigeria's Fourth Republic and represent distinct crisis types: democratic transition, economic protest, security protest, electoral contestation, and a contemporary governance scenario [1999; 2012; 2020; 2023; 2024–2025]. This span allows us to test whether breakdown of embodied order is recurrent or episodic.

4.3 Ethics and Positionality

Research was conducted with prior community consent in Anaañ communities. All national case materials are public record. The author's positionality is that of an Anaañ scholar reading Nigerian politics through an Ekpo grammar, in dialogue with Wiredu's philosophy and Bakhtin's dialogism.

5. FINDINGS: FIVE MOMENTS OF BREAKDOWN, 1999–2025

5.1 1999: Transition Without Translation

The May 29 handover performed a centripetal geometry: the new civilian authority occupied a symbolic centre at Eagle Square while publics remained peripheral spectators. Rhythm was ceremonial, not responsive: the tempo of inauguration did not match the tempo of popular expectation after military rule. Relation was declarative: speeches announced democracy, but mechanisms for translating popular demands into policy were underdeveloped. The embodied order was inaugurated in dissonance [United Nations, 1998; Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1999].

5.2 2012: Occupy Nigeria and Spatial Rupture

Fuel subsidy removal produced acute centre-periphery dissonance. State authority retreated to institutional centres — Aso Rock, NNPC offices — while publics occupied urban peripheries: Gani Fawehinmi Park, streets, bridges. Tempo clashed: protests accelerated within days, while government dialogue lagged weeks. Relationally, gestures were oppositional: barricades versus batons, slogans versus silence. Translation was minimal until economic reversal was announced

[Heinrich Böll Stiftung, 2012]. The leadership vacuum was visible as geometric rupture.

5.3 2020: #EndSARS and Collapsed Relation

Here dissonance intensified across all three dimensions. Spatially, police authority claimed fixed posts and toll gates while dispersed, networked publics occupied multiple urban nodes. Temporally, youth mobilisation was immediate and viral, while state response oscillated between denial and force. Relationally, the mode collapsed: communication broke down, and at Lekki Toll Gate, translation failed entirely [CNN, 2020; Amnesty International, 2020]. The event revealed a geometry where centre could no longer hold, rhythm could not be shared, and relation could not be repaired.

5.4 2023: Electoral Contestation and Fractured Tempo

The 2023 elections displayed choreogeometric tension at scale. Authority claimed a legal-institutional centre through INEC, while publics and candidates contested that centre in courts, streets, and digital spaces. Tempo was fractured: official electoral time versus viral real-time reporting. Relation was adversarial: opposing gestures of “victory” and “theft” with limited institutional translation [Independent National Electoral Commission, 2024]. The geometry exposed a centre that could not integrate competing rhythms.

5.5 2024–2025: Governance Scenario

In contemporary policy debates — subsidy reforms, security restructuring, fiscal federalism — the pattern persists. Authority announces from a distant centre, adjusts slowly, and struggles to translate elite calculus into public idiom. Publics respond with dispersed, rapid mobilisations. The embodied order remains in breakdown rather than alignment [Arise News, 2024; ThisDay, 2025].

6. DISCUSSION: FROM BREAKDOWN TO POLYRHYTHMIC GOVERNANCE

If breakdown is the diagnosis, what restores order? We propose an Ekpo-inspired model of *polyrhythmic governance* grounded in Bakhtinian answerability.

6.1 Mobile Centre: From Throne to Circle

Ekpo teaches that authority must move. A polyrhythmic state relocates decision-making closer to affected publics — town halls, regional assemblies, digital fora — and allows centre to be exchanged rather than monopolised. This enacts the Ekpo principle of mobility of centre.[Field notes held by author with community consent in Abak & Ikot Ekpene, 2024–2025; Offiong, 1984]

6.2 Attuned Tempo: From Delay to Dialogue

Ekpo demands that drums and dancers align. A polyrhythmic state builds feedback loops that match policy tempo to public tempo: rapid consultation, visible response, and iterative adjustment. This enacts the Ekpo principle of shared tempo.[Field notes held by author with community consent in Abak & Ikot Ekpene, 2024–2025; Offiong, 1984]

6.3 Translated Relation: From Opposition to Mediation

Ekpo requires the mask to translate. A polyrhythmic state institutionalises translation mechanisms: citizen assemblies, cultural mediators, and non-partisan custodial roles that convert sectional demand into collective language. This enacts the Ekpo principle of dialogic translation and meets Bakhtin's criterion of answerability [Field notes held by author with community consent in Abak & Ikot Ekpene, 2024–2025; Offiong, 1984; Bakhtin, 1986].

6.4 Wiredu's Custodianship

Wiredu's non-partisan leadership finds embodied form here. Custodians do not compete to occupy a fixed centre; they rotate, translate, and align rhythms. This is leadership as choreography, not conquest.

This custodial model also resonates with Malunga's articulation of Ubuntu-based leadership as service, relationality, and community-centred accountability.[Wiredu][1997][Malunga][2009]

7. CONCLUSION: REHEARSING EMBODIED SOCIAL ORDER

Nigeria's leadership vacuum between 1999 and 2025 is not only institutional; it is embodied. The breakdown of social order appears as clashing geometries of centre, rhythm, and relation. Anaañ Ekpo offers a cultural grammar for alignment. Wiredu offers a philosophical warrant. Bakhtin offers a theory of how dialogue, when it fails, produces dissonance.

Choreogeometry does not promise a perfect performance. It offers a lens to see when the body politic is out of step, and a vocabulary to rehearse order. Nigeria is the exemplar, but the framework travels. Future work will operationalise these dimensions across comparative cases. For now, the task is conceptual: to name the breakdown and imagine the polyrhythm that might succeed it.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

All national case materials are publicly accessible via broadcast archives, newspaper repositories, and online media. Anaañ community consultation materials are held by the author in accordance with community consent agreements.

ETHICS STATEMENT

Community consent was obtained from Anaañ traditional and youth structures in Abak and Ikot Ekpene prior to fieldwork. The research involved no risk beyond everyday public discourse and used only publicly available records for national cases.

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